



PUBLIC IDOL
Albert Ball was a fearless pilot and excellent marksman who became the first British ace to be idolized by the public. He was still only 20 when his plane crashed under mysterious circumstances in May 1917.

famous ace, Baron von Richthofen, was, “I hope he roasted the whole way down.” But even those who were less savage in their rejection of the ethic of chivalry took great pleasure in a “kill.” Fighter pilots drove to view the wreckage of aircraft they had shot down over their own lines, to examine the bodies and collect souvenirs.

Richthofen himself was a renowned collector of mementos of his victories.

There is no doubting the adrenalin rush that many individuals experienced through combining the thrills of fighting and flying – even though “laughing in the face of danger” is an attitude found in postwar memoirs rather than in contemporary letters or diaries. Many soldiers stuck in damp verminous trenches undoubtedly looked on airmen with envy. A flier had a warm, dry, lice-free bed 10 or 15 miles behind the lines; there was never any shortage of volunteers for the air services. Yet the war in the air had more in common with the war in the trenches than is often recognized. There was a grueling attrition of pilots and aircraft. Freshly trained British pilots arriving at the front in 1917 had an average life-expectancy of a little over two weeks. Like “shell-shocked” infantry, airmen were prone to nervous breakdowns as the strain of combat intensified and losses mounted. Every ace was first and foremost a survivor.

Pilot material

Fighter pilots were of varied origins. A good number, like Richthofen, transferred from the cavalry, which had lost its function in the face of barbed wire and the machine gun. Some, like the British ace James McCudden or the German Werner Voss, were drawn to aviation because of an interest in machines and worked their way up from ground crew to

pilots. Some of the best fliers, including the indomitable French ace Charles Nungesser, had been sportsmen. Pilots in general were extremely young. British ace Albert Ball was a squadron leader at the age of 19. Many of them were also quite short – cockpits were small and weight was a prime factor in aircraft performance. Guynemer was a case in point: he weighed less than 132lb (60kg) and had been rejected as too frail for service in the infantry.

Many would-be fighter pilots never made it as far as the front line. The air services were largely unprepared for the challenge of training thousands of new pilots. The result was a great waste of young lives. Almost 500 American Air Service volunteers died learning to fly, more than twice the number killed in combat. Most cadets were introduced to the controls of an aircraft either through being taken up by an instructor or, in France, “flying” on the ground in flightless “aircraft” known as Penguins. But at some point they had to take the controls themselves. Although training aircraft were chosen for their inherent stability, one moment of panic could be fatal. Many novices forgot the simplest principles

SHOOTING PRACTICE

An airman undergoes weapons training as his “cockpit” moves along rails in a primitive attempt to simulate the difficulty of hitting enemy aircraft in a dogfight. Many pilots were sent to the front without ever having fired a gun.

